

# nl(1) — Linux manual page

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 *NL*(1)

User Commands

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## NAME [top](#)

nl – number lines of files

## SYNOPSIS [top](#)

nl [*OPTION*]... [*FILE*]...

## DESCRIPTION [top](#)

Write each FILE to standard output, with line numbers added.

With no FILE, or when FILE is -, read standard input.

Mandatory arguments to long options are mandatory for short options too.

-b, --body-numbering=STYLE  
use STYLE for numbering body lines

-d, --section-delimiter=CC  
use CC for logical page delimiters

-f, --footer-numbering=STYLE  
use STYLE for numbering footer lines

-h, --header-numbering=STYLE  
use STYLE for numbering header lines

-i, --line-increment=NUMBER  
line number increment at each line

-l, --join-blank-lines=NUMBER  
group of NUMBER empty lines counted as one

-n, --number-format=FORMAT  
insert line numbers according to FORMAT

-p, --no-renumber

do not reset line numbers for each section

**-s, --number-separator=STRING**  
add STRING after (possible) line number

**-v, --starting-line-number=NUMBER**  
first line number for each section

**-w, --number-width=NUMBER**  
use NUMBER columns for line numbers

**--help** display this help and exit

**--version**  
output version information and exit

Default options are: **-bt -d'W:' -fn -hn -il -ll -n'rn' -s<TAB> -v1 -w6**

CC are two delimiter characters used to construct logical page delimiters; a missing second character implies ':'. As a GNU extension one can specify more than two characters, and also specifying the empty string (**-d ''**) disables section matching.

STYLE is one of:

a      number all lines

t      number only nonempty lines

n      number no lines

pBRE   number only lines that contain a match for the basic regular expression, BRE

FORMAT is one of:

ln      left justified, no leading zeros

rn      right justified, no leading zeros

rz      right justified, leading zeros

## AUTHOR [top](#)

Written by Scott Bartram and David MacKenzie.

## REPORTING BUGS [top](#)

Report bugs to: [bug-coreutils@gnu.org](mailto:bug-coreutils@gnu.org)  
GNU coreutils home page: <<https://www.gnu.org/software/coreutils/>>  
General help using GNU software: <<https://www.gnu.org/gethelp/>>  
Report any translation bugs to  
<<https://translationproject.org/team/>>

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## SEE ALSO [top](#)

Full documentation <<https://www.gnu.org/software/coreutils/nl>> or available locally via: info '(coreutils) nl invocation'

## COLOPHON [top](#)

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GNU coreutils 9.11

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